

TEACHER TRAINING FRAMEWORK

A Complete Guide to Planning, Teaching, and Assessing

For Novice and Experienced Teachers · Online Instruction

Curriculum Design Division

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How to Use This Guide

This framework is your complete reference for delivering the curriculum you have been entrusted with. It covers every stage of a lesson cycle; from understanding who your learners are, to setting goals, to teaching each phase of the lesson structure, to assessing outcomes and reflecting on your practice.

The guide is organised in the order that mirrors your workflow as a teacher:

- Read the full guide once before you teach your first lesson. Understanding the whole picture will help you make better decisions in the moment.
- Return to individual sections as needed; each section is self-contained and cross-referenced.
- Pay special attention to the sections on your learner group (age and level).
- Use the Quick-Reference tables when planning each lesson.
- Read the Troubleshooting section before each new group you take on.

Icon / Label	Meaning
Tip for Online Classes	Practical advice specific to the online teaching context
Watch Out	Common pitfalls to avoid
Example	A classroom-ready example or script
Key Definition	A core concept defined concisely
Phase boxes	Step-by-step guidance for each lesson phase

1. Understanding the Curriculum Philosophy

Before you teach a single lesson, you must understand the design principles behind the curriculum. These are not background trivia; they directly shape every decision you make in the classroom.

1.1 Contextualisation as the Core Principle

Every lesson in this curriculum is built around contextualisation: language is always introduced and practised inside a meaningful, real-world context rather than in isolation. Grammar rules are never presented as abstract formulas. Vocabulary is never drilled out of context. Instead, language emerges naturally from a situation that students can relate to.

The primary vehicle for this context is the dialogue. Each lesson's main input is a conversation between characters whose identities, relationship, and situation are chosen to be relevant and credible for the target age group and level. Students encounter language the way they would encounter it in real life: embedded in meaning, emotion, and social purpose.

Why contextualisation works

When students see language in a context that feels real, their brain makes stronger meaning connections. Retention is higher, motivation is stronger, and transfer to real communication is more natural. Your job is to preserve and amplify that context; never strip it away by jumping straight to grammar explanations.

1.2 The Interconnected Lesson Sequence

The lessons in this curriculum are not standalone units. Each lesson connects to the ones before and after it; thematically, linguistically, and structurally. This means:

- Language from Lesson 1 reappears in Lesson 3. Do not skip ahead or reorder lessons without curriculum approval.
- Characters recur across lessons. Students build familiarity with them over time, which deepens engagement.
- Themes build on each other progressively. A theme introduced at one level reappears at a higher level with more complexity.
- Skills developed in one lesson are extended in the next. The speaking practice in Lesson 4 prepares students for the freer activity in Lesson 5.

Tip for Online Classes

In your online classroom, keep a running note visible to students (in the chat or on a shared screen) of 'what we covered last time.' This activates prior knowledge and reinforces the curriculum's connected structure.

1.3 Theme-Level-Age Alignment

Each lesson is mapped to a specific combination of theme, proficiency level, and age category. These three factors are always considered together by the curriculum designer; a theme that works for adult beginners may be entirely inappropriate (or uninteresting) for young beginners at the same level.

Age Category	General Theme Profile	Tone & Style
Young Learners (7–11)	Family, animals, school, colours, daily routines, food, simple emotions	Playful, high-energy, visual, game-rich
Teens (12–17)	Friendship, hobbies, school life, technology, pop culture, environment	Relatable, slightly edgy, peer-focused, activity-based
	Identity, social issues, future plans, relationships, media, travel	Authentic, respectful, debate-friendly, project-oriented
Adults (18–25+)	University, work, independence, current events, culture, relationships	Realistic, intellectually stimulating, discussion-rich
	Work, family, travel, finance, health, society, self-development	Practical, respect-based, context-rich, professionally relevant

Watch Out

Never try to 'simplify' a lesson by removing the context or replacing the dialogue. The context IS the lesson. Simplify delivery, not design.

2. Needs Analysis & Learner Profiling

Before planning the delivery of any lesson, you must know your learners. A needs analysis is not a luxury; it is the foundation of all effective teaching. The curriculum has been designed for specific learner profiles, and your job is to understand which profile your class matches, and where individuals diverge from it.

2.1 What Is a Needs Analysis?

Needs Analysis

A systematic process of gathering information about learners' backgrounds, current proficiency, goals, learning preferences, and constraints; so that instruction can be appropriately targeted and differentiated.

2.2 What to Find Out Before Your First Lesson

For a new class or a new student, gather information across four dimensions:

Dimension	Key Questions to Investigate
Linguistic profile	What is their current level? What are their strongest and weakest skills (speaking, listening, reading, writing)? What is their L1? Are there fossilised errors to be aware of?
Learner goals	Why are they studying English? What do they need it for? Work, exams, travel, social communication? Are their goals short-term or long-term?
Learner context	How much time can they dedicate? Have they studied English before? What methods have they been exposed to? What has frustrated them in the past?
Affective factors	How confident are they? Are they anxious about speaking? Do they have a high or low tolerance for ambiguity? What motivates them intrinsically?

2.3 How to Conduct a Needs Analysis Online

In an online setting, needs analysis happens through several channels:

- A personality sheet (filled during the first session (Get to Know).
- A diagnostic session at the start of the first part of the curriculum.
- Careful observation of how the student interacts during the first two sessions.
- A brief conversation in the target language (or L1 if necessary) about their goals.

Tip

Pin a message in the chat before your first session: ask two questions: 'What do you most want to be able to do in English?' and 'What do you find hardest?' The answers will guide every adaptation you make.

2.4 The Learner Profile Card

After your first two sessions, you should be able to complete a learner profile card for each student or group. Keep this updated as you go.

Profile Element	What to Note
Level	Assigned level + any significant gaps or strengths vs. level
Age	Actual age + maturity level (some students are above or below their age)
Primary goal	The one thing they most want to achieve
Strongest skill	Speaking / Listening / Reading / Writing
Area most needing work	The skill or language area that limits them most
Engagement triggers	What gets them interested (games, stories, real-world tasks, debate...)
Confidence level	High / Medium / Low — especially for speaking
Special considerations	Learning differences, time zones, tech issues, noisy environment, etc.

3. Setting Goals & Learning Outcomes

Every lesson you teach must have a clear purpose. That purpose is expressed through learning outcomes; specific, observable statements of what students will be able to do by the end of the lesson. This section shows you how to identify, understand, and communicate those outcomes effectively.

3.1 What Is a Learning Outcome?

Learning Outcome

A statement describing what a student will be able to **DO** at the end of a lesson, not what the teacher will have taught. Outcomes are learner-centred, specific, and observable.

Strong outcome: "By the end of this lesson, students will be able to *introduce* themselves and ask for basic personal information in a conversation."

Weak outcome: "Students will *learn* the verb to be." This describes content, not capability.

3.2 Bloom's Taxonomy: Your Planning Tool

Bloom's Taxonomy is a framework that classifies cognitive tasks from lower-order thinking (recall, recognition) to higher-order thinking (creating, evaluating). It is essential for two things: writing outcomes at the right level of challenge, and sequencing activities correctly within a lesson.

Bloom's Level	What it Means + Classroom Application
1. Remembering (lowest)	Recalling facts, vocabulary, rules. Activities: labelling, matching, flashcards, gap-fills, listen-and-repeat. When: warmup, vocabulary introduction.
2. Understanding	Explaining meaning in own words; showing comprehension. Activities: answering comprehension questions, paraphrasing, describing a dialogue. When: post-dialogue discussion, concept checking.
3. Applying	Using language in a guided context. Activities: role-plays, sentence construction, guided speaking tasks. When: guided and partially guided practice.
4. Analysing	Breaking down language; noticing patterns; comparing. Activities: error correction, comparing two dialogues, identifying register. When: language focus, pronunciation analysis.
5. Evaluating	Judging, arguing, giving opinions with justification.

Bloom's Level	What it Means + Classroom Application
	Activities: debates, expressing preferences with reasons, peer assessment. When: free practice, outro discussion.
6. Creating (highest)	Producing original language for a new purpose. Activities: creating their own dialogue, writing a short script, free role-play. When: free activity, extension task for advanced students.

Within a single lesson, you will typically move upward through Bloom's levels, starting at Remember/Understand during the warmup and input phases, moving through Apply in guided practice, and reaching Evaluate or Create in free practice.

Tip

If you notice that all your activities in a lesson sit at levels 1–2, you are not pushing students to actually use the language, only to recognise it. Push toward level 3 (Apply) as your minimum target for every lesson.

3.3 Communicating Outcomes to Students

Students learn better when they know what they are learning and why. Share the lesson outcome at the start, in student-friendly language, not academic jargon.

Example

"Today we're going to practise how to talk about your plans for the weekend. You'll be able to do this confidently by the end of class."

Return to the outcome at the end of the lesson during closure: ask students to self-assess ("Can you now do X?") and celebrate progress explicitly.

Tip

Share the lesson outcome at the start. Students can refer back to it and it creates a sense of direction, especially important when attention is harder to sustain remotely.

4. Sequencing: Building the Lesson Flow

A lesson is not a collection of activities; it is a carefully sequenced experience that moves students from unfamiliarity to confident use. Sequencing is about the logical and psychological order in which content and tasks appear.

4.1 The PPP Framework in This Curriculum

This curriculum follows a PPP (Presentation → Practice → Production) structure, enriched with a contextualised warmup and a pronunciation phase. Understanding why activities are ordered the way they are will help you deliver them with confidence and adapt them when necessary.

PPP Stage	What Happens / What Students Do
Presentation	New language is introduced inside a meaningful context. Students encounter the target language in the dialogue/story before they are expected to use it themselves.
Practice	Students work with the language in controlled (guided), semi-controlled (partially guided), and free conditions. Errors are expected and used as learning opportunities.
Production	Students use the language freely for communicative purposes. The goal is fluency and personal expression, not accuracy.

4.2 Lesson Sequence Map

The following table maps each phase of your lessons to the PPP stage and Bloom's level it targets:

Lesson Phase	PPP Stage	Bloom's Level(s)
Warmup	Pre-Presentation	Remember, Understand
Intro to the theme	Presentation (context)	Understand
Main input (dialogue)	Presentation (language)	Remember, Understand
Outro of the theme	Presentation → Practice bridge	Understand, Apply
Guided activities	Practice (controlled)	Apply
Partially guided activities	Practice (semi-controlled)	Apply, Analyse
Free activities (speaking)	Production	Evaluate, Create

Lesson Phase	PPP Stage	Bloom's Level(s)
Listening / Reading / Gamification	Practice (receptive)	Remember → Apply
Pronunciation practice	Practice (form-focused)	Remember, Analyse, Apply

4.3 The 'Known to Unknown' Principle

Always move from what students already know toward what is new. This applies both across lessons (each lesson builds on the previous one) and within a single lesson (the warmup recalls prior knowledge before new content is introduced).

When you introduce a new language, anchor it to something familiar; a word they already know, a situation they have already encountered, or a structure that resembles something from their L1.

Tip

If a student seems lost when a new structure appears, backtrack: find something they DO know and build a bridge from there. Use the whiteboard or a shared document to write the bridge connection visually.

4.4 Pacing: Managing Time in Online Lessons

Online lessons require tighter pacing than face-to-face lessons. Cognitive load is higher (students are managing a screen, audio, and chat simultaneously), so attention windows are shorter.

Phase	Recommended Duration (guide only)
Warmup	5 minutes
Intro to the theme	5 minutes
Main input (dialogue)	15 minutes
Outro of the theme	5 minutes
Guided practice	20 minutes
Partially guided practice	20 minutes
Free speaking activity	25 minutes
Listening / Reading / Game	20 minutes
Pronunciation practice	5 minutes

Watch Out

- Never rush through the dialogue to 'get to' the activities. The dialogue IS the lesson, it is the primary input. If you are running short on time, reduce the free activity, not the input or guided practice.
- The lesson plan is **flexible**; each section can take more or less time depending on the needs of the students, lesson objectives, etc

5. The Lesson Structure: Phase-by-Phase Guide

This section is your primary classroom reference. It takes you through every phase of the lesson structure with detailed guidance on what to do, how to do it, what to watch for, and how to adapt for different levels and ages.

Phase 1 · Warmup

- **Purpose:** Activate prior knowledge, lower the affective filter, energise the group, and create a bridge from the previous lesson.
- **Duration:** 5 minutes.
- Never skip it! The warmup is not filler. It is neurologically important: it moves students from 'outside mode' into 'learning mode.'

What to do during the warmup

- Review 2–3 key items from the previous lesson: a question, a vocabulary item, or a short recall activity.
- Use a short question, image, sound, or mini-game that connects thematically to the lesson ahead, but do not reveal the theme yet.
- Keep it interactive: every student should speak or respond within the first two minutes.
- Smile, use the student's name, and set the tone; energy in the warmup carries through the lesson.

Age/Level Group	Warmup Ideas
Young Learners (Beginner)	Simple TPR actions, a song or chant, naming a flashcard image, 'What colour is this?'
Young Learners (Elementary+)	A short guessing game, true/false about the previous lesson, a picture prompt
Teens (Beginner)	A vocabulary race in the chat, quick-fire questions, 'Odd one out' with words from last lesson
Teens / Adults (Intermediate+)	A discussion starter ('What did you do yesterday?'), a short poll, a topic-related image to comment on
Adults (Advanced)	A short provocative question related to the theme, a brief news headline, a quote to react to

Tip

Use the 'breakout' or raise-hand feature to call on different students during the warmup. This avoids the same students always speaking first and gives you a quick read on who is comfortable that day.

Phase 2 · Intro to the Theme

- **Purpose:** Introduce the lesson's theme and generate anticipation. Build semantic context before the dialogue.
- **Duration:** 5 minutes.
- Think of this as 'opening the frame', you are setting the scene, not teaching the language yet.

What to do during the theme introduction

- Name the theme in an engaging way, not a dry announcement.
- Activate topic-related vocabulary students already know before introducing new items.
- Connect the theme to the students' lives: 'Have you ever...?', 'Do you know anyone who...?', 'What does X mean to you?'

Concept Check Question (CCQ)

A question designed to check whether a student has genuinely understood the meaning of a word, not just repeated it. A CCQ cannot be answered with the word itself. Example for 'exhausted': 'If I'm exhausted, do I want to go dancing or sleep?' Students cannot answer 'exhausted', they must demonstrate understanding.

Example

Theme: 'City Spaces' (Adult, B1 level)

Teacher: *'Has anyone here ever moved to a different city or country? What was the hardest thing about it?' [Show an image of a packed suitcase and an empty apartment.] 'Today we're going to hear from someone in exactly that situation. Before we read, let me check a few words you'll need...'*

Tip for Online Classes

Share the image or visual stimulus directly in the video call (screen share) rather than describing it verbally. Visuals dramatically increase comprehension and engagement in online lessons.

Phase 3 · Main Input: The Dialogue

- **Purpose:** Present new language in its full contextual richness. This is the lesson's primary input.
- **Duration:** 15 minutes.
- This is the heart of the lesson. The dialogue is not background material, it is the vehicle that carries all the target language.

Principles for delivering the dialogue

- Always introduce the characters before reading the dialogue: who they are, their relationship, and the situation they are in.
- Use the dialogue as reading input first, then as a model for speaking.
- Ask questions that give students a reason to interact: 'What problem does Mourad have?' or 'Who do you think is more nervous?'
- After finishing the dialogue, check global comprehension before asking about language details.
- Use follow-up questions that push beyond recall: 'Why do you think he said that?', 'How does Yacine feel at the end?'

Step	Action
1. Set the scene	Introduce characters and situations. 2–3 sentences. Use the visuals.
2. Pre-reading task	Give one simple question to focus attention while reading ('What is the main problem?')
3. First read	Students encounter the dialogue for the first time. No interruptions.
4. Check global comprehension	Answer the pre-reading questions. Confirm basic understanding before going further.
5. Second encounter/review (if found)	Recall, with a more detailed task (true/false, ordering events).
6. Language focus	Draw attention to specific target language in the dialogue. Do not 'teach' it yet, guide students to notice it first.
7. Contextual check	Discuss: 'Why did character X use this expression here? What does it tell us about the situation?'

Watch Out

Do not explain every vocabulary item in the dialogue. Teach students to tolerate ambiguity and infer meaning from context; this is a core real-world reading/listening skill. Focus only on items that are critical to comprehension.

Phase 4 · Outro of the Theme

- **Purpose:** Close the thematic frame, consolidate understanding, hint to the upcoming lesson, and bridge from input to practice.
- **Duration:** 5 minutes.

- This phase brings the dialogue's world to a close and helps students reflect before they start producing language themselves.

What to do in the outro

- Invite a brief personal reaction: 'What do you think about what happened? Have you been in a similar situation?'
- Do a final concept check: 'Can anyone explain what X means using their own words?'
- Signal the transition: 'Now that we've seen how [Character] handled this, let's practise it ourselves.'

The outro is also the moment to differentiate explicitly, for stronger students, invite analysis ('Was there a better way [Character] could have handled this?'). For weaker students, focus on consolidation of meaning, trigger curiosity to see what will happen next.

Phase 5 · Practice Section

- **Purpose:** Move students from understanding to active language use through a progression of guided → partially guided → free activities.
- **Duration:** 60 minutes total across all practice activities.
- The practice section is where students actually learn to use the language, it requires your highest level of facilitation skill.

5a. Guided Activities (Controlled Practice)

In guided activities, the language choices are largely made for the student, they fill in, complete, match, repeat, meet requirements. The cognitive load is low enough that students can focus entirely on the language form.

- Provide a clear model before every guided activity: show students exactly what a correct response looks like.
- Correct errors immediately and gently during guided practice, this is the phase where accuracy matters most.
- Keep turns short, all students should respond at a high frequency, not just the most confident ones.

Tip

For online guided practice, use the chat as a rapid-response board. Ask a question, give 15 seconds, and ask all students to say their answer simultaneously (but not say until you say 'go'). This avoids students copying each other and gives you instant class-wide data.

5b. Partially Guided Activities (Semi-Controlled Practice)

Here students have more choices, but still within a defined structure. A role-play with prompts, a sentence-building task with cues, or a discussion with provided vocabulary are all partially guided.

- Move from teacher-fronted to student-to-student interaction, use pair or small group tasks.
- Give clear task parameters: who speaks to whom, about what, for how long.
- Monitor without interrupting, note errors for delayed correction after the task.
- Use delayed error correction: write down 3-4 common errors heard during the task, then discuss as a class after, without attributing errors to individuals.

Tip

In online classes, use breakout rooms for pair and small group partially guided tasks. Brief breakout sessions (5 minutes) dramatically increase individual speaking time compared to whole-class format.

5c. Free Activities (Production)

In free activities, students express their own ideas, opinions, or experiences using the target language. Accuracy takes a back seat to fluency and communicative success.

- **Set an authentic communicative goal:** not 'use the present perfect' but 'tell your partner about an experience that changed you.'
- **Do not interrupt to correct during free activities,** only intervene if communication breaks down completely.
- **After the task, conduct brief positive feedback:** highlight two or three examples of effective language use you noticed.
- **Follow free activities with a targeted post-task** language focus if a systematic error pattern emerges.

5d. Listening / Reading / Gamification Activities

These activities provide variety, reduce speaking fatigue, and develop receptive skills. They are always tied to the lesson's theme and target language.

Activity Type	How to Deliver It Online
Listening task	Play audio through your screen share (check that 'share computer audio' is ticked). Provide a focus question before playing. Replay as needed, do not assume students caught everything on the first pass.
Reading task	Share the text on screen. Allow sufficient silent reading time before asking questions. Use the annotation tool to highlight key words.
Gamification (quiz, race, game)	Use tools such as Kahoot, Quizlet Live, Wordwall, etc. Brief games (5-10 min) spike motivation and consolidate vocabulary. Always debrief the language after the game.

Phase 6 · Pronunciation Practice

- **Purpose:** Develop students' phonological awareness and ability to produce intelligible, natural speech.
- **Duration:** 5 minutes.
- Pronunciation is not an add-on, it is a core communication skill. Every lesson ends with dedicated pronunciation work tied to the lesson's language.

Delivering pronunciation practice effectively

- Always connect pronunciation work to language from the dialogue, students hear it in context, then analyse it, then produce it.
- **Model first, always.** Students hear a correct model before they attempt production.
- Use minimal pairs for discriminating similar sounds: 'ship / sheep', 'but / bat'.
- Teach word stress explicitly, use syllable tapping, capitalization, to show where stress falls.
- Teach connected speech features at intermediate levels and above: linking, weak forms, elision, assimilation.

Level	Pronunciation Focus
Absolute Beginner	Individual sounds (phonemes), basic word stress, the sounds of the alphabet
Elementary	Word stress in common words, /θ/ and /ð/, final consonant clusters
Pre-Intermediate	Sentence stress, weak forms of function words (the, a, to, of...)
Intermediate	Connected speech: linking and intrusive sounds, contractions in natural speech
Upper-Intermediate	Intonation patterns (rise/fall for questions and statements), attitudes through intonation

Level	Pronunciation Focus
Advanced	Register variation in pronunciation, discourse-level intonation, reduction in fast speech

Tip for Online Classes

Use the mute-all / unmute-all function to do whole-class choral repetition online. Ask all students to repeat a phrase simultaneously, the online format actually reduces the embarrassment of individual pronunciation attempts, since students can hide in the chorus.

6. Strategies & Techniques by Level and Age

This is one of the most important sections of this guide. No single teaching strategy works equally well for all levels and all ages. This section gives you targeted strategies for each learner profile, along with specific techniques drawn from the curriculum's structure.

6.1 Absolute Beginners

Absolute Beginner (A0)

A student with little or no prior exposure to English. They cannot yet form complete sentences, have a very limited vocabulary, and may not be familiar with the Roman alphabet (in some cases).

Core strategies

- **Use visual anchoring:** always pair a new word/concept with an image, gesture, or object. Never introduce vocabulary through translation alone.
- **Keep TTT (Teacher Talking Time) short:** use simple, clear language and pause frequently.
- **Prioritise listening before speaking:** allow students to respond with a gesture, a word, or a translation before expecting full sentences.
- **Chunk language:** present fixed phrases rather than isolated words. 'Nice to meet you' is more useful than teaching 'nice', 'to', and 'meet' separately.
- **Repeat and recycle constantly:** new items need to appear at least 7 times in different contexts before they are retained.
- **Celebrate every small success loudly and specifically:** *'Perfect, your pronunciation of 'hello' is exactly right!'*

Technique	How to Apply with the Lesson Structure
Drilling (choral and individual)	After every new item in the dialogue, conduct a brief drill: choral → sub-group → individual. Keep it energetic and fast-paced.
TPR (Total Physical Response)	For young beginners especially, students respond to instructions with actions. 'Stand up. Touch your nose. Jump!' Increases engagement and embodied learning.
Substitution drills	Give a model sentence and change one element at a time: 'My name is Tom.' → 'My name is ____.' Students fill in their own name.
Realia and visuals	Use real objects or clear images on screen. For young learners, a physical toy or puppet can play the role of one of the dialogue characters.

Tip for Online Classes

For absolute beginners online, keep your screen background clean and uncluttered. Use your camera, and ensure your face and mouth are clearly visible, beginners rely heavily on lip-reading and facial expression to decode meaning.

6.2 Elementary to Pre-Intermediate (A1–A2+)

At this stage, students have a basic foundation. They can produce simple sentences but often rely on heavily memorised chunks. The key challenge is moving them from memorised phrases toward more flexible, generative language use.

- **Encourage risk-taking:** praise attempts even when incorrect. The goal is to reduce reliance on exact memorised phrases.
- **Begin to draw attention to patterns:** 'Look, every time we talk about the past here, what does the verb ending look like?'
- **Introduce simple error correction techniques:** recasts (repeat the utterance correctly without explicitly marking the error) and prompts ('Can you say that again? Remember we need...')
- **Start to use the dialogue for inductive language discovery,** guide students to notice and articulate the rule before you state it.

6.3 Intermediate (B1)

Intermediate students have enough language to communicate but often hit the 'intermediate plateau' — where progress feels slower and errors become more fossilised. Teaching at this level requires stimulating and authentic tasks.

- Push students beyond safe, rehearsed language, design tasks that require them to reach beyond their comfort zone.
- Use partially guided tasks that require genuine information exchange, not just scripted repetition.
- Introduce the concept of register: formal vs. informal, written vs. spoken, and how the dialogue reflects these.
- Make error correction more explicit, students at B1 can handle metalanguage ('That's a subject-verb agreement error. Why?').
- Begin self- and peer-assessment during free activities.

6.4 Upper-Intermediate to Advanced (B2–C1/C2)

Advanced students need intellectual engagement as much as language practice. They can communicate effectively but need to refine accuracy, expand range, develop nuance, and express complex ideas.

- Move toward discussion-heavy and debate-style activities in the free practice phase.
- Focus on vocabulary depth (connotation, collocation, register) rather than breadth.
- Analyse the dialogue for pragmatic features: what is implied but not said? What does the character's word choice reveal?
- Use the dialogue as a springboard for extended writing or presentation tasks.
- Encourage self-correction and peer feedback with a structured feedback protocol.

6.5 Young Learners (Ages 7–11)

Young learners are not mini-adults. They learn fundamentally differently, through play, movement, repetition, story, and social interaction. Every strategy you use must account for this.

- **Keep activities short** (3–5 minutes each) and switch formats frequently.
- **Use songs, chants, and rhymes** to support vocabulary and pronunciation, these are not just fun, they are neurologically powerful for language acquisition.
- **Tell stories using the characters in the dialogue**, young learners connect with narrative and character more than with abstract tasks.
- **Use gamification as the primary practice mode**: every practice activity should feel like a game.
- **Manage energy**: alternate high-energy activities (games, movement) with quieter ones (colouring, drawing, listening).
- **Parents may be present online; acknowledge this**, set expectations, and involve them positively in supporting their child.

Tip for Online Classes

For online young learner classes, use a virtual 'reward jar', a simple whiteboard, where you draw stars or stickers during the lesson. The visual accumulation of rewards is highly motivating and maintains focus across a 45-minute online session.

6.6 Pre-Teens and Teenagers (Ages 11–17)

Teenagers are often the most challenging group to teach, not because they cannot learn, but because their motivation, social dynamics, and identity concerns are more complex. The right approach unlocks enormous engagement.

- **Respect their intelligence**: never talk down to them, and choose tasks that feel genuinely relevant to their lives.
- **Use peer interaction extensively**, teenagers are more motivated by the opinion of their peers than by teacher approval.

- **Give choices wherever possible:** which character they play, which topic they discuss, how they present their work.
- **Create a psychologically safe environment for error,** do not cold-call nervous students; build confidence gradually.
- **Avoid over-praising minor achievements,** teenagers detect inauthenticity immediately. Specific, earned praise works; generic praise does not.
- **Use the dialogue characters as discussion anchors:** 'Do you agree with what Rayan did? What would you have done?'

Tip for Online Classes

For online teen classes, use the chat actively, some teenagers who are too self-conscious to speak will write freely. Use chat responses as a bridge to speaking: 'I saw Mourad said [X], who can you tell us more about that?'

6.7 Adult Learners

Adult learners bring rich life experience, strong intrinsic motivation, and clear goals, but also heightened anxiety about error, less tolerance for what feels 'childish,' and significant time pressure. Respect these realities in every design and delivery choice.

- **Always make the relevance explicit:** 'We're practising this because in a job interview, you will likely be asked exactly this type of question.'
- **Leverage their experience:** use their professional or life context as the content for free activities.
- **Do not infantilise;** avoid games that feel juvenile or tasks without clear real-world application.
- **Build autonomy:** teach strategies (not just language), encourage self-correction, and help them study effectively outside class.
- **Be flexible with sensitive topics;** the dialogue themes are designed to be relatable, but an adult may have personal experience that makes a topic difficult. Handle with care and offer alternatives.

7. Scaffolding: Supporting Without Limiting

Scaffolding

Temporary instructional support that enables students to perform a task they could not yet complete independently. Scaffolding is gradually removed (faded) as competence grows. Named after Vygotsky's Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD).

Scaffolding is the skill that separates a good teacher from an average one. Too much scaffold and students never develop independence. Too little and they become frustrated and give up. The right amount is in the ZPD (zone of proximal development), the zone where the task is challenging but achievable with support.

7.1 Types of Scaffolding

Scaffold Type	Examples
Linguistic scaffolding	Sentence starters ('I think...', 'In my opinion...'), word banks, partially completed sentences, grammar frames ('I have never ____ed because ____').
Content scaffolding	Pre-teaching vocabulary before the dialogue, concept maps, visual organisers, background context about the dialogue's setting.
Task scaffolding	Breaking a complex task into smaller steps, providing an example of a completed task, modelling the activity before students attempt it.
Social scaffolding	Pairing a weaker student with a stronger one (carefully), using the teacher as a model partner before students work together.
Metacognitive scaffolding	Guiding students to monitor their own understanding: 'Before you answer, take a moment to think about which tense we need here.'

7.2 The Gradual Release Model

The practice section of every lesson follows a gradual release structure, moving from maximum teacher support to full student independence.

Phase	Who Does the Work?
I do (Guided activity)	Teacher models. Students observe and practise with full support.
We do (Partially guided)	Teacher and students work together. Students take more initiative with prompts available.
You do (Free activity)	Students work independently or with peers. The teacher monitors from a distance.

Tip for Online Classes

In online classes, use the whiteboard or a shared document as your 'scaffolding anchor', display sentence frames or vocabulary support in a corner of the screen throughout the guided and partially guided phases. Remove it visibly before the free activity:

Example: "OK, I'm going to take the word bank away now. You've got this."

7.3 Fading the Scaffold

The most common mistake teachers make with scaffolding is not removing it. If students still have access to sentence starters and word banks during the free activity, they are not producing language, they are selecting it. Scaffolds must be explicitly faded:

- Make scaffolding visible and tangible (a word bank on screen, a sentence frame on the shared doc).
- Tell students it is being removed: *'Now I'll take the word bank away, try to remember the vocabulary.'*
- In subsequent lessons, do not provide the same scaffold for the same language, review instead.

Watch Out

Fading a scaffold too quickly causes anxiety and failure. Keeping it too long creates dependency. The right pace depends on the student; watch for signs of competence (fewer hesitations, more accurate production) before you fade.

8. Assessment & Feedback

Assessment is not something that happens at the end, it happens throughout every lesson. The goal of assessment in this curriculum is twofold: to give students meaningful information about their progress, and to give you the information you need to adapt your teaching.

8.1 Formative vs. Summative Assessment

Type	What It Is / When It Happens
Formative assessment (assessment for learning)	Ongoing, informal checking of understanding during and after lessons. Helps the teacher adjust instruction in real time. Examples: CCQs, chat responses, observation during activities, exit tickets, quick polls.
Summative assessment (assessment of learning)	Formal measurement of what students have achieved at the end of a unit or period. Examples: a structured speaking task, a written test, etc.

In your day-to-day teaching, formative assessment is your primary tool. Use it constantly; after every explanation, after every activity, at the end of every lesson.

8.2 Checking for Understanding: Techniques

"Does everyone understand?" is not a check for understanding. It is a check for confidence, and confidence *does not* always correlate with comprehension. Use these techniques instead:

- CCQs (Concept Check Questions): see Section 5, Phase 2.
- ICQs (Instruction Check Questions): before an activity, check that students know what they are supposed to do. *"Are you going to write or speak?"*, *"Are you working alone or with a partner?"*
- Mini-production tasks: ask students to use the target language in a short original sentence before moving on.
- Chat polls: 'Type A if you feel confident, B if you need more practice, C if you are lost.' Respond to each result.
- Targeted questions to quieter students, done with care and warmth, not as a catch-out.
- End-of-lesson exit ticket: one sentence about what they learned, one question they still have.

Tip for Online Classes

In online classes, use the reaction buttons (thumbs up, heart, confused face) for rapid pulse checks. Ask students to react to a statement like "I understand how to use the present perfect in a question" and read the room immediately.

8.3 Error Correction

Error correction is one of the most nuanced skills in teaching. Done well, it accelerates learning. Done poorly, it damages confidence and reduces willingness to speak. Use the following framework:

Phase of Lesson	Error Correction Approach
Guided practice	Immediate and explicit: correct clearly, model the correct form, ask the student to repeat it. This is the phase for accuracy work.
Partially guided practice	Delayed and indirect: note errors during the task, then address patterns (not individuals) after the task.
Free activity	Minimal: only intervene if communication breaks down. Note errors for post-task language focus.
Pronunciation practice	Immediate and specific: model the sound, describe the mouth position if needed, contrast with the error.

Techniques for correction:

- **Recast:** repeat the student's utterance with the correct form: Student: 'Yesterday I go to school.' Teacher: 'You went to school — good! What time?'
- **Prompt:** signal that an error was made without providing the correction: 'Can you say that again? Think about the tense.'
- **Elicitation:** 'Almost! What do we say after I have? I have...' [pause for student to self-correct].
- **Metalinguistic cue:** 'Check your verb ending — we're talking about the past.'

8.4 Giving Feedback to Students

Feedback is most powerful when it is specific, timely, and actionable. Avoid generic praise ('Good!', 'Well done!'), it tells students nothing useful.

Example

Instead of: 'Good job!' Say: ***'I really liked how you used 'however' to contrast your two ideas, that's exactly the kind of linking language we need at your level.'*** Instead of: 'Your pronunciation needs work.' Say: ***'The word stress on 'photograph' caught my attention, let's look at that together: PHO-to-graph.'***

For written feedback (via chat or follow-up message), use the *'two stars and a wish'* structure: two specific things they did well, one specific thing to work on.

8.5 Student Self-Assessment and Autonomy

Teaching students to assess their own language is one of the highest-value things you can do. It builds metacognitive awareness and supports learning between sessions.

- After free activities, ask students to reflect: 'Was there a moment where you weren't sure which word to use? What did you do?'
- Introduce students to the CEFR 'can-do' statements; help them understand where they are and what the next step looks like.
- Encourage vocabulary journals: students record new words from each dialogue with their own example sentence.
- End each lesson with a specific self-study suggestion: 'Listen to the dialogue one more time tonight and try to shadow the character's speech.'

9. Online Teaching: Principles & Best Practices

All lessons in this curriculum are delivered online. This is not a limitation, it is a context with its own strengths and challenges. This section addresses what is unique about online teaching and how to use the medium effectively.

9.1 Setting Up for Success

Technical Element	Best Practice
Camera	Always on. Position at eye level so you appear to look directly at students. Good lighting from the front (not behind you). A clean, neutral background.
Microphone	Use a headset or external microphone. Built-in laptop microphones often pick up keyboard noise and echo. Test audio before every session.
Screen sharing	Practice screen sharing your materials before the lesson. Close all unrelated tabs and notifications. Know how to share your sound for audio activities.
Backup plan	Have a phone ready as a mobile hotspot in case your internet drops. Save key materials in the chat before the lesson starts so students have them even if you disconnect.
Materials prep	Open all tabs, documents, videos, and games before the lesson. Fumbling with materials kills pacing and loses student attention rapidly.

9.2 Managing the Online Classroom

- Establish clear online norms in the first session: camera on (where possible), microphone muted when not speaking, use the raise-hand feature, contribute actively in the chat.
- Use names constantly; in an online environment, students feel invisible if not addressed directly. Say their name before asking them a question.
- Vary your interaction patterns: whole class → individual → pairs (breakout) → whole class. Never stay in one mode for more than 15 minutes.
- Maintain a higher energy level than you would face-to-face, the screen flattens energy. You need to compensate with voice variation, facial expression, and pacing.
- Never lecture for more than 5 minutes without an interactive element, attention drops dramatically online after about 4 minutes of passive input.

9.3 Maximising Student Talking Time (STT)

In a face-to-face class, students might naturally speak 20–30% of the time. Online, this often drops to 10–15% unless you actively design for it. Use these strategies to increase STT:

- **Breakout rooms:** send students into pairs for 5-10 minutes for any partially guided or free task.
- **Simultaneous chat responses:** 'Everyone type your answer in the chat, but don't press Enter yet. OK, go!', all responses appear at once.
- **Record-and-share:** ask students to record a short voice message or short video for homework, then play it at the start of the next lesson.
- **Give students a role:** discussion leader, reporter, timekeeper, this increases accountability and talking.

9.4 Recommended Online Tools

Tool / Feature	Best Use in This Curriculum
Virtual whiteboard (Miro, Jamboard, platform whiteboard)	Brainstorming in warmup, vocabulary mapping, collaborative task display
Kahoot / Quizlet Live	Gamification activities, vocabulary review, etc
Wordwall	Interactive games for vocabulary, grammar, pronunciation (replace gap-fills with game format)
Google Slides (shared)	Teaching materials, collaborative tasks, dialogue reconstruction, sentence-building exercises
Padlet	Free activity output display; students post their answers/ideas for class discussion
Chat	Rapid comprehension checks, simultaneous responses, sharing dialogue text, posting vocabulary
Breakout rooms	Pair and small group practice for all partially guided and free activities
Screen annotation / spotlight	Highlighting language in the dialogue, marking pronunciation stress, annotating text

10. Troubleshooting: Common Issues & Solutions

Every experienced teacher has faced these situations. This section gives you practical, tested strategies for the most frequent challenges you will encounter, especially in an online context.

10.1 Student Engagement Issues

Issue	Solution
Student has camera off and seems disengaged	Address privately: 'I find it easier to teach when I can see you — is everything OK?' Do not force it publicly. If the policy requires cameras on, escalate to the academic coordinator, not the student.
Student is very quiet and rarely speaks	Never cold-call this student without warning. Build gradually: invite them first in the chat ('Type one word that describes the character'), then into a breakout pair, then into whole class discussion.
Student dominates the conversation	Use structured turns explicitly: 'Let's hear from someone who hasn't spoken yet.' Use the raise-hand feature. In breakouts, separate the dominant student.
Group energy is low (Monday morning syndrome)	Have an emergency warmup game ready. Do not force productivity before re-establishing group energy.
Student is distracted by their environment (noisy background, family members)	Ask gently if they can move or use headphones. Build flexible routines that accommodate real-world constraints, avoid making the student feel guilty.

10.2 Language & Learning Issues

Issue	Solution
Student seems stuck at the same level despite lessons	Conduct a brief needs re-analysis. The plateau may reflect: fossilised errors that need explicit attention, a mismatch between the level and the student's actual proficiency, or insufficient practice between sessions. Report to the academic coordinator.
Student makes the same error repeatedly	This is fossilisation, the error has become a habit. Use repeated, explicit correction over several lessons. Create a personalised 'error target' for this student and address it consciously in guided practice.
Student cannot follow the dialogue	Check: is the level appropriate? Are there too many unknown vocabulary items? Pre-teach more vocabulary in the theme intro phase. Allow students to read along while listening.
Mixed-level group making it impossible to pitch correctly	Use tiered tasks during practice (same task, different scaffold level). Give advanced students an extension question. Give weaker students a sentence frame. This is differentiation in action.

Issue	Solution
Student translates everything into L1 before responding	This is normal at lower levels, do not penalise it. Gradually increase the response speed expectation. Use tasks that require an immediate physical or visual response (pointing, reacting) before verbal production.

10.3 Technical Issues (Online)

Issue	Solution
Student's internet drops repeatedly	Have an asynchronous backup ready: a shared doc with the day's activities they can complete and send. Do not hold up the whole class, continue and debrief with the student afterward.
Audio echo or feedback	Immediately ask all students to mute except the speaker. Identify who is causing the echo (ask them to mute temporarily). If unresolved, switch to text-based interaction for that student.
Screen share does not work	Have materials ready in the chat as a backup (PDF, link, pasted text). Alternatively, describe what you would show and send the file for students to open independently.
Student cannot hear the audio file	Share the audio file directly in the chat and ask them to play it on their own device. Or share a transcript and turn it into a reading task.
The lesson runs significantly overtime	Cut from the free activity or the pronunciation phase, never from the input or guided practice. Note what was not covered and integrate it into the next lesson's warmup.

10.4 Classroom Management Issues

Issue	Solution
Students speak L1 during pair tasks (breakout rooms)	Set a clear expectation before sending them to breakouts: 'English only, I may drop in to listen.' Actually do visit breakout rooms so the expectation is real.
Students are not doing homework or self-study	Make the link between self-study and in-class success explicit and concrete. Assign specific, manageable tasks (listen to the dialogue once, review 5 words) and follow up warmly at the start of the next lesson.
A student challenges the level or the material	Take it seriously: 'Thank you for telling me. Let me check in with you during today's lesson and we'll assess together.' Involve the academic coordinator if a level change is warranted.

Issue	Solution
A student becomes upset or emotional during a lesson	Pause. Acknowledge. Do not push forward with the lesson content. Offer a short break. Handle privately via chat if possible. Report to the academic coordinator if there is a welfare concern.

10.5 Quick Reference: Lesson Planning Checklist

Use this checklist every time you prepare a lesson:

Before the lesson							
Read the lesson and in full	Check the target language and the outcomes	Identify any vocabulary to pre-teach in the theme intro	Brain storm CCQs for new vocabulary	Decide on scaffold level for your group	Verify any digital tools (Kahoot, Wordwall, shared doc)	Review the previous lesson briefly for warmup content	Test your audio, camera, and screen share
During the lesson							
Share the lesson outcome at the start	Activate prior knowledge in the warmup	Set a pre-reading task before the dialogue	Check comprehension with CCQs after input phases	Use gradual release across practice phases	Use breakout rooms for pair practice	Do not correct during free activities	Close with a specific, actionable exit reflection

11. The Things They Don't Tell You: Real Teaching Wisdom

Everything in the sections above is important. But there is a layer of teaching knowledge that does not appear in training manuals: the hard-won insight that comes from hundreds of hours in the classroom. This section is that layer. It is honest, direct, and designed to actually change how you teach.

11.1 Your Lesson Plan Is a Hypothesis, Not a Contract

A lesson plan is your best prediction of what will happen. It is never a guarantee. The moment you forget this, you start making one of teaching's most common and damaging mistakes: forcing the plan through regardless of the room.

If a student's question opens up exactly the understanding you were going to spend fifteen minutes building, **follow the question**. If the dialogue lands flat because the theme is unexpectedly sensitive for this particular group on this particular day, **pivot**. If an activity catches fire and students are genuinely engaged in deep, real language use, **do not cut it off because you are 'behind.'**

The rule

Your plan serves the students. The students do not serve your plan. A lesson where you ditched the plan and met the learners where they were is a better lesson than one where you completed every activity and nobody learned anything.

In practice, this means:

- Plan thoroughly, but hold the plan lightly. The work you do planning is never wasted even when you don't use it, because it gives you the deep familiarity with the material to improvise well.
- Identify your lesson's non-negotiables before you start: the one or two things that must happen regardless. Everything else is negotiable.
- Build 'accordion activities' into your plan, tasks you can expand if you have time or compress if you don't, without losing the learning.
- When you abandon part of the plan, tell students why: 'We're going to skip the reading today because this conversation is more valuable right now.' Transparency builds trust.

Tip for Online Classes

Keep a running mental note during every lesson: **'Am I doing this because it serves these students right now, or because it's on the plan?'** That question alone will make you a significantly better teacher.

11.2 Learn to Read the Room: And Act on What You See

Reading the room is the most underrated teaching skill. It is the difference between a teacher who delivers a lesson and a teacher who teaches people.

In an online environment, the signals are subtler but they are still there. You are looking for:

Signal	What It Might Mean / What to Do
Camera off, no chat activity	Disengagement, embarrassment, or a technical issue. Address it, do not pretend it isn't happening.
Everyone suddenly very quiet after an activity	Either deep thinking (good) or confusion (act). Ask: 'Take a moment, then tell me one thing that was difficult about that.'
One student answering everything, others silent	The others are either lost, bored, or afraid to be wrong. Explicitly redirect: 'Thank you, let's hear from someone else now.'
Short, clipped answers where you expect elaboration	The question is too hard, the topic feels risky, or they are tired. Lower the cognitive load or change the format.
Students asking questions about something you covered earlier	You moved on too fast. Backtrack. Do not pretend the confusion did not happen.
Students going significantly off-topic in discussion	They are engaged but need redirecting, do it warmly: 'I love where this is going, and let's park it here and come back. What I want us to focus on is...'
Suddenly high energy and laughter during an activity	Something is working. Note it. Use it again. Do not kill the energy by moving on too quickly.

Reading the room also means noticing when a student seems off before the lesson content even starts; a one-word greeting where they are usually chatty, a camera positioned away from their face, a message that is more formal than usual. These are not things to ignore. A thirty-second check-in ('Everything okay today?') can completely change the session.

Watch Out

The biggest room-reading failure is noticing a signal and rationalising it away, '*They're probably just tired*', and carrying on. Trust your instinct. If something feels off, it probably is.

11.3 Teach the Way You Would Want to Be Taught

This is not a platitude. It is a rigorous design principle. Before every activity, every explanation, every correction choice, ask yourself: if I were the student, anxious, trying hard, maybe exhausted from a

long day, would I find this useful? Would I find this respectful? Would this make me feel capable or incapable?

Specifically, this means:

- Never explain something for longer than the student can hold attention. You do not need to say everything you know about the present perfect in one lesson. Say what they need, check it landed, and move on. The rest can come later.
- Never correct in a way that makes a student feel stupid. There is no such thing as a necessary public humiliation. Correction is information, not punishment.
- Do not make students wait. Drawn-out explanations while one student finishes a task are experienced as boredom and disrespect by everyone else. Have something for students to do while you give individual attention.
- Do not perform enthusiasm you do not feel. Students, especially teenagers, detect fake energy instantly and it alienates them. Authentic engagement at a lower pitch beats performed excitement every time.
- Give students the full picture. Do not say *'for now, just do it this way'* without ever explaining why. Students who understand the reason behind a rule remember it far better and feel more respected.

Example

Think of the worst lesson you have ever sat through as a student. What made it bad? Now think of the best. What made it work? Write those two lists down. The second list is your teaching standard. The first is your list of things to never do.

11.4 Silence Is a Teaching Tool: Use It

Most teachers, when faced with silence after a question, rush to fill it. This is one of the most common ways teachers inadvertently prevent learning.

When you ask a good question and the room goes quiet, that silence is often **thinking**. Cognitive processing is happening. The moment you break it with a hint, a rephrasing, or a different question, you interrupt that process and take the intellectual work back for yourself.

The research on wait time is unambiguous: extending the pause after a question from one second to three to five seconds consistently produces longer, more complex, more accurate student responses. In an online environment, where there is latency, where students cannot lean over to a neighbour, and where the pressure of a camera can make thirty seconds of silence feel like a minute, this is even more important to remember.

- Ask the question clearly and completely.
- Stop talking.
- Wait. Count to five in your head if you have to.
- If still no response, rephrase once, then wait again.
- If still nothing, use it as diagnostic information: the question was too hard, or the topic needs more scaffolding.

Tip for Online Classes

In online classes, say *'I'm giving you thirty seconds to think, no rush'* before you go silent. This normalises the pause and removes the anxiety of not knowing why the teacher has stopped speaking.

11.5 Your Relationship with Students Is the Curriculum

You can have perfect lesson plans, the best materials, and a flawless command of methodology, and students will still not learn well from a teacher they do not trust, feel safe with, or feel seen by.

This does not mean being a friend. It means being a professional who genuinely sees each student as an individual with specific strengths, specific struggles, specific fears, and specific goals, and who demonstrates that consistently.

- **Remember details.** If a student mentioned last week that they had a job interview, ask about it this week. The information is in your learner profile card. Using it signals: ***I was listening. You matter.***
- **Be consistent.** Students, especially children and teenagers, need to know what to expect from you. If you are warm and patient one day and rushed and dismissive the next, you create anxiety rather than safety.
- **Repair ruptures.** If you were short with a student, or a correction landed badly, or a session felt tense, **name it.** *'Last week felt a bit difficult, I want to make sure we are good.'* This takes thirty seconds and it can save a student who was about to quietly disengage.
- **Maintain appropriate boundaries online.** The informality of the online environment can blur professional lines. Keep sessions professional even when the relationship is warm. Do not share personal problems with students. Do not conduct sessions from inappropriate locations.

11.6 When Things Go Sideways: Improvise Without Panicking

At some point, a lesson will fall apart. The activity will not work. The topic will land wrong. A student will say something that derails everything. Your internet will drop. Two of your four students will not show up. The dialogue will be too difficult and nobody will understand it.

When this happens, **the worst thing you can do is pretend it is not happening and push through.** The second worst thing is to **panic visibly**. Students take their emotional cue from you, if you stay calm and confident, the session recovers. If you fall apart, so does the room.

Your improvisation toolkit:

Situation	Improvisation Move
An activity completely fails or students disengage	Stop it cleanly: <i>'OK, let's approach this differently.'</i> Do not apologise excessively. Move to something simpler: ask an open question about the theme and let discussion carry the time. Debrief to yourself later why it failed.
A student asks a language question you cannot answer	The honest answer is always the right one: <i>'That's a great question, I want to make sure I give you an accurate answer, so let me come back to you on that.'</i> Then actually do. Students respect intellectual honesty far more than bluffing.
The lesson is going way too fast and you have 20 minutes left	Go deeper, not wider. Return to something from earlier in the lesson and push it further. Ask a higher-order question. Invite students to create their own dialogue using the target language. Never pad with busywork.
A student says something that creates an awkward or tense moment	Acknowledge it without amplifying it. <i>'That's an interesting perspective, let's hear what others think.'</i> Move the conversation. Address it with the student privately afterward if necessary.
You completely lose your train of thought	Say so. <i>'I've lost my thread, give me two seconds.'</i> Pause, recover, continue. This happens to every teacher. Students do not lose confidence in a teacher who is human. They lose confidence in one who pretends to be infallible and fails.
Two students are not getting along in a breakout	Regroup breakouts immediately without explanation. Pair them differently. Address the dynamic privately after the session, not in front of the group.

After every session that did not go as planned, do one thing: write down what happened and what you would do differently. Not to punish yourself — to build your repertoire. The teachers with the largest repertoire of recovery moves are the ones who have failed the most and paid attention to every failure.

11.7 The Energy You Bring Is Contagious: For Better or Worse

Students feel your energy before you say a single word. If you open a session distracted, flat, or stressed, the class will absorb it. This is not about performing positivity, it is about managing your state consciously as a professional responsibility.

- **Build a pre-session ritual.** Even ninety seconds of intentional preparation, reviewing your non-negotiables, taking a few deep breaths, reading your learner notes, can shift your state meaningfully.
- **Use your voice as an instrument.** Vary your pace, your pitch, and your volume deliberately. A raised pace signals excitement. A slower, quieter voice signals importance and draws students in. Monotone is the enemy of attention.
- **Move on camera.** Lean in when a student says something interesting. React visibly to their responses. In an online environment, physical stillness reads as disengagement, even small gestures communicate presence and attention.
- **If you are having a genuinely hard day, it is okay to briefly acknowledge it:** *'I'm a little tired today so I might need your energy to carry us, let's start with something fun.'* This is honest, human, and it often makes students more rather than less engaged.

11.8 Stop Talking. *Seriously.*

TTT, Teacher Talking Time, is the single most common problem in language teaching, and it is invisible to most teachers who have it. If you are talking for more than 40% of a lesson, you are not teaching a language class. You are delivering a monologue with occasional interruptions.

Language acquisition requires language production. Students cannot become fluent in English by listening to their teacher. Every extra minute you spend explaining is a minute students are not practising. Every time you answer a question you could have redirected to *'What do the rest of you think?'* **you are removing a production opportunity.**

Practical TTT reduction:

- **Give instructions in two sentences maximum.** Model the activity immediately after. Students learn more from a model than from a long explanation.
- **When a student asks a vocabulary question, do not define it immediately.** Ask the class first: *'Does anyone know this word?'* Then use context: *'Look at the sentence around it, what do you think it means?'*
- **Use the chat for instructions where possible:** typed instructions reduce the need to repeat yourself, which saves significant talking time.
- **After posing a question, do not rephrase it within five seconds.** Ask it once, clearly, then wait.
- **Record yourself once a month and count.** Most teachers who do this are genuinely shocked by how much they talk.

Tip for Online Classes

A simple test: if you removed your voice from the lesson recording, would students have been doing anything? If the answer is 'not much,' your TTT is too high.

11.9 Feedback Is a Skill: Give It Like One

Most feedback given in language classrooms is either too vague ('Good!'), too late (written comments returned a week later), or too negative (a list of errors). None of these drive improvement. Feedback is only useful when it is specific, timely, and delivered in a way the student can act on.

The most powerful feedback happens in the moment, but it requires you to listen carefully rather than prepare your next explanation. Here is what separates feedback that changes behaviour from feedback that gets forgotten:

- **Name what worked specifically before naming what did not.** Not because you need to be diplomatic, but because students need to know what to keep doing, not just what to stop.
- **Correct one thing at a time.** When you identify three errors in a single student utterance and address all three, they remember none of them. Choose the one that matters most for their current level and target that.
- **Make the correction a question when possible:** *'You said you go, does that sound right for yesterday?'* The student who self-corrects retains the correction far better than the student who was corrected.
- **Follow up.** If you corrected something last week, listen specifically for it this week and comment on improvement: *'I noticed you used the past tense perfectly just now, last week that was catching you out. Well done.'* This tells students you are actually paying attention, and it makes correction feel like progress rather than judgment.

11.10 Take Care of Yourself: It Directly Affects Your Teaching

This is not a generic wellness tip. It is a professional requirement. Teaching online is cognitively and emotionally demanding in ways that are easy to underestimate. The combination of sustained screen time, active listening, emotional labour, and performance energy depletes you faster than most jobs.

A depleted teacher cannot read the room. Cannot improvise. Cannot give quality feedback. Cannot hold the energy a class needs. The most professional thing you can do for your students is to show up resourced.

- **Protect the thirty minutes after a teaching session.** Do not schedule back-to-back classes without a genuine break in between. What you call 'just one more class' is often the one where you do the most damage.

- **Debrief your sessions, briefly and honestly.** Three questions: what worked? What did not? What will I do differently? Five minutes. Then let it go.
- **Find a peer you can speak honestly to about difficult students, difficult days, and approaches that are not working.** Isolation accelerates burnout. Reflection with a trusted colleague accelerates growth.
- **Do not carry students' problems.** You are responsible for the quality of their instruction, not for their life circumstances. Care deeply within the session. Maintain a boundary after it.

A final reflection for this section

The teachers that students remember for decades are not the ones with the most elaborate lesson plans or the deepest grammatical knowledge.

They are the ones who made students feel seen. Who held high expectations and high warmth at the same time. Who never stopped learning themselves.

That is what this section is really about. Methodology is learnable. These qualities are a choice, made again, in every session.

A Final Word

Teaching is one of the most complex and rewarding professional skills there is. This framework gives you the principles and the tools, but what will make the difference is your presence, your care, and your willingness to keep learning alongside your students.

The curriculum you have been given is carefully designed. Trust it, use it fully, and resist the temptation to replace its contextualised, dialogue-based approach with more traditional teaching. Every design decision was made for a reason.

When in doubt: return to the principles. Know your learners. Set clear outcomes. Deliver the dialogue in its full context. Support students with the right scaffold. Push toward production. Give specific, kind feedback. Reflect. Improve.

You are not just delivering a lesson, you are opening a door. We trust you to do it with skill and care.

Rayene Medabis